notion that an individual should be free to believe as he will, and that in a free society one's beliefs should be shaped by his mind and his conscience rather than coerced by the State. See *Elrod* v. *Burns, supra,* at 356–357; *Stanley* v. *Georgia,* 394 U. S. 557, 565; *Cantwell* v. *Connecticut,* 310 U. S. 296, 303–304. And the freedom of belief is no incidental or secondary aspect of the First Amendment's protections:

> "If there is any fixed star in our constitutional constellation, it is that no official, high or petty, can prescribe what shall be orthodox in politics, nationalism, religion, or other matters of opinion or force citizens to confess by word or act their faith therein." *West Virginia Bd. of Ed.* v. *Barnette,* 319 U. S. 624, 642.

These principles prohibit a State from compelling any individual to affirm his belief in God, *Torcaso* v. *Watkins,* 367 U. S. 488, or to associate with a political party, *Elrod* v. *Burns, supra;* see 427 U. S., at 363–364, n. 17, as a condition of retaining public employment. They are no less applicable to the case at bar, and they thus prohibit the appellees from requiring any of the appellants to contribute to the support of an ideological cause he may oppose as a condition of holding a job as a public school teacher.

We do not hold that a union cannot constitutionally spend funds for the expression of political views, on behalf of political candidates, or toward the advancement of other ideological causes not germane to its duties as collective-bargaining representative.[32] Rather, the Constitution requires only that

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force him to conform to any other establishment in all cases whatsoever?" 2 The Writings of James Madison 186 (Hunt ed. 1901). Thomas Jefferson agreed that " 'to compel a man to furnish contributions of money for the propagation of opinions which he disbelieves, is sinful and tyrannical.' " I. Brant, James Madison: The Nationalist 354 (1948).

[32] To the extent that this activity involves support of political candidates, it must, of course, be conducted consistently with any applicable (and constitutional) system of election campaign regulation. See gen-